

South Asian independence

The struggle for Indian independence intensified during the early 20th century as more people began to protest against British rule. In 1947, India achieved freedom but it was partitioned (divided) into two countries—India and Pakistan. In 1971, East Pakistan broke away to form Bangladesh.

Most of the Indian subcontinent had been under the direct control of the British government since 1858. In the early 20th century, the leaders of the Indian independence movement demanded self-rule from the British government and launched many campaigns to achieve this. In 1920, a leading figure of the independence movement, Mahatma Gandhi, launched the Non-Cooperation Movement, urging people not to buy British goods. He followed it up by calling for all Indians to engage in civil disobedience—a form of nonviolent protest where people refused to obey any unjust laws.

By 1945, British rule had weakened and it was decided that power would soon be transferred to Indians. However, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, a key

leader of the freedom struggle, asked for a separate homeland for Muslims. Eventually, the British agreed to do this. On August 14, 1947, the new country Pakistan came into existence, and a day later, India gained independence.

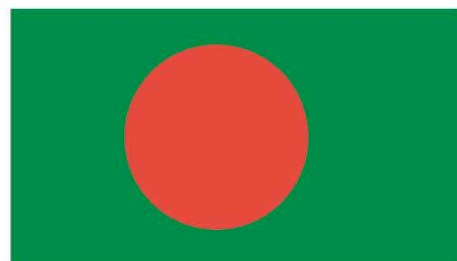
MAHATMA GANDHI

Mohandas K. Gandhi (1869–1948), popularly known as Mahatma Gandhi, was an Indian lawyer and freedom fighter. He championed civil disobedience and nonviolent resistance in India's struggle for independence.



▲ QUIT INDIA MOVEMENT

The slogan “Quit India” was launched by Gandhi on August 9, 1942. His demand for Britain to bring a complete end to its rule in India was met with widespread support. He urged for civil disobedience, inspiring people from across the country to take part in workers strikes and nonviolent marches. The British responded by imprisoning nearly all the movement's leaders.



▲ BANGLADESH IS BORN

Twenty years after Pakistan was created, the people of East Pakistan demanded more economic and political powers, and fought for independence. Their victory in the Bangladesh War of Independence led to the creation of The People's Republic of Bangladesh in 1971.

PARTITION OF INDIA ►

In August 1947, the Indian subcontinent was divided into two countries. In the following months, millions of people moved across the new borders of India and Pakistan on foot, in bullock carts, and on trains. Muslims living in India fled to West and East Pakistan, while Sikhs and Hindus traveled to India. It was one of the largest human migrations in history. Violence and riots broke out between different religious communities. By 1948, more than a million people had died in the riots, and more than 15 million people had become refugees.

